

Pulse Diagnosis Lecture Primer



The 28 Pulse Qualities

FCM Chapter 25 · CAM Chapter 13
Normal Pulse Components · 28 Classical Pulse Qualities

⚠ **Quiz 2 — July 24, 2026** (Week 2 material — tomorrow!)

TCM for Ballroom Dancers | Dance Medicine Specialty

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PRE-LECTURE READING (BEFORE JUL 25)

FCM Chapter 25 — Maciocia: Normal pulse, 28 qualities, clinical groupings, significance of each

CAM Chapter 13 — Cheng Xinnong: Normal pulse, 28 pathological types, pulse-taking method, Yin/Yang groupings

THE NORMAL PULSE — 平脈 Píng Mài

Quality	Description	Factor	Normal Variation
Rate	4–5 beats/respiration (72–80 bpm)	Season	Spring: wiry · Summer: flooding · Autumn: floating · Winter: deep
Depth	Middle level — not too superficial, not too deep	Age	Children: faster · Elderly: deeper, weaker
Strength	Forceful but not excessive; soft but not empty	Gender	Women: softer; right slightly larger
Rhythm	Regular — no skipped or irregular beats	Build	Tall: slower · Short: faster · Thin: superficial · Heavy: deeper
Three Essentials 胃神根 Wèi 胃 — Stomach Qi: flowing, gentle, harmonious Shén 神 — Spirit: strong, rhythmical, responsive Gēn 根 — Root: deep at Chi; Kidney Qi present		Exercise	Faster, fuller; returns to normal at rest
		Emotion	Fear → rapid · Anger → wiry · Grief → thin
		Food/Preg.	Slippery after meals; slippery at Cun in pregnancy

PULSE POSITIONS — 寸關尺

Position	Cun 寸 (distal)	Guan 關 (middle)	Chi 尺 (proximal)
Left Hand	Heart / SM Intestine chest, Pericardium	Liver / Gallbladder	Kidney (Yin) / Bladder Lower Jiao (L)
Right Hand	Lung / LG Intestine chest	Spleen / Stomach	Kidney (Yang) / Bladder Lower Jiao (R)

⚠ FLOATING PULSE TRAP (FROM WK 2 — LIKELY ON QUIZ 2!)

Floating ≠ always Exterior. In Yin deficiency (night sweats, five-palm heat, malar flush) → **Floating + Empty = Empty Heat**. Context determines pattern.

28 PULSE QUALITIES — COMPLETE REFERENCE

7 GROUPS TO ORGANIZE YOUR THINKING

Floating · Sinking · Rate · Strength · Width/Shape · Rhythm · Composite — feel the group first, then the specific quality within it

Pulse (CN/Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Group / Key Note
► FLOATING GROUP 浮 — felt at superficial level			
Floating 浮 Fú	Easily felt superficially; weakens with pressure	Exterior patterns; Yin def (floating + empty)	↑ Depth
Hollow 芤 Kōu	Floating, large, soft — hollow in middle (scallion stalk)	Loss of Blood or fluids (heavy bleeding, profuse sweat)	↑ Depth + hollow center
Leather 革 Gé	Floating, taut, large, hollow — firm outside, empty inside (drum)	Loss of Jing/Blood; uterine bleeding; seminal emission	↑ Depth + hard surface
► SINKING GROUP 沉 — felt only at deep level			
Deep 沉 Chén	Only with heavy pressure at bone level	Interior patterns; Qi stagnation; pain; Water retention	↓ Depth
Firm 牢 Láo	Deep, wiry, forceful; remains hard under pressure	Accumulation of Cold; abdominal masses	↓ Depth + hard
Hidden 伏 Fú	Deeper than Deep; felt only at bone with very heavy pressure	Severe Interior Cold; fainting; extreme pain	↓ Depth extremis
► RATE GROUP — beats per respiration			
Rapid 數 Shuò	>5 beats/resp (>90 bpm)	Heat (Full or Empty); extreme Qi exhaustion	↑ Rate
Slow 遲 Chí	<4 beats/resp (<60 bpm)	Cold (Full or Empty); Yang deficiency	↓ Rate
Racing 疾 Jí	Extremely rapid (>7 beats/resp, >120 bpm)	Extreme Heat consuming Yin; dying Yang floating upward	↑ ↑ Rate extremis

Pulse (CN/Pingin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Group / Key Note
Moderate 緩 Huǎn	4 beats/resp; even, relaxed; slightly slow	Normal (if regular); Dampness; Spleen Qi def (if weak)	Normal/Damp
► STRENGTH GROUP — force / amplitude			
Full / Replete 實 Shí	Large, forceful at all three levels; no weakening on pressure	Excess patterns; Full Heat; excess Fire	↑ Force
Empty / Deficient 虛 Xū	Soft, weak at all three levels; weakens further on pressure	Deficiency patterns; Qi/Blood def	↓ Force
Weak 弱 Ruò	Deep, soft, fine; only at deep level with light touch	Qi and Blood def; Yang deficiency	↓ Force + deep
Frail / Minute 微 Wēi	Extremely thin, soft; barely perceptible; nearly absent	Severe Qi, Yang, Blood def; collapse	↓↓ Force extremis
► WIDTH / SHAPE GROUP			
Wiry 弦 Xián	Taut, tense; like pressing a violin string; long	Liver/GB patterns; pain; Phlegm; Damp; old age (normal)	Taut
Slippery 滑 Huá	Smooth, flowing; like pearls rolling on a dish	Phlegm/Damp; Heat; pregnancy (normal); after meals (normal)	Smooth
Choppy 澀 Sè	Uneven, rough, hesitant; like scraping bamboo with a knife	Blood stasis; Blood/Fluid def; Jing deficiency	Rough/Uneven
Flooding 洪 Hóng	Large, forceful; rises like a wave then fades	Excess Heat; Summer Heat; exertion (normal)	Large + wave force
Thin / Fine 細 Xì	Thin like a thread; clearly perceptible; not weak	Blood def; Yin def; Damp (if slippery + thin)	Narrow width
Soggy / Soft 濡 Rú	Floating, thin, and soft; disappears on pressure	Dampness; Blood deficiency; Summer Damp	Float + thin + soft
Long 長 Cháng	Extends beyond all three positions	Excess patterns; Liver Fire; Full conditions	↑ Length
Short 短 Duǎn	Does not reach both ends; felt in one position only	Qi deficiency or stagnation	↓ Length
► RHYTHM GROUP — regularity			
Knotted 結 Jié	Slow + irregular; occasional missed beats; no fixed interval	Qi stagnation; Blood stasis; Phlegm; Cold	Slow + irregular skips
Hurried 促 Cù	Rapid + irregular; occasional missed beats; no fixed interval	Excess Heat; Qi/Blood/Phlegm/Food stagnation	Rapid + irregular skips
Reg. Intermittent 代 Dài	Slow; misses beat at REGULAR fixed intervals	Organ Qi declining; serious Heart condition; pain; fright	Slow + regular gaps ⚠ worst
► COMPOSITE / OTHER			
Tight / Tense 緊 Jǐn	Like a taut twisted rope; more tense/vibrating than Wiry	Cold (Interior or Exterior); pain; retained food	Taut + twisting
Overflowing 大 Dà	Wide, large; like Flooding but without wave force	Full Heat; early febrile disease	Large width

CLINICAL GROUPINGS — MACIOCIA FCM Ch.25

Exterior / Interior	Def / Excess	Qi / Blood Def
• Exterior: Floating, Tight, Rapid	• Def: Empty, Thin, Weak, Frail, Choppy, Soggy	• Qi Def: Empty, Weak, Frail
• Interior: Deep, Wiry, Slippery, Choppy, Full	• Excess: Full, Wiry, Slippery, Flooding	• Blood Def: Thin, Choppy, Weak
Cold / Heat	Phlegm / Blood Stasis	Organ Positions
• Cold: Slow, Tight, Deep, Firm	• Phlegm: Slippery, Soft, Wiry	• Liver: Wiry (Left Guan)
• Heat: Rapid, Flooding, Full, Slippery	• Stasis: Choppy, Wiry, Firm	• Kidney Def: Deep + weak at Chi
		• Spleen Def: Weak at Right Guan

EASILY CONFUSED PAIRS — TEST HIGH-YIELD

Pair	Pulse A	Pulse B	Key Differentiator
Floating vs Hollow	Floating: weakens; not hollow	Hollow: floating + hollow center (scallion)	Press center — Hollow feels empty inside

Slippery vs Flooding	Slippery: smooth rolling; normal width	Flooding: large wave, forceful rise + fade	Flooding is LARGE; Slippery is smooth but not necessarily large
Wiry vs Tight	Wiry: taut like violin string	Tight: taut + twisting/vibrating rope	Tight has a twisting vibrating quality; Wiry simply taut
Thin vs Soggy	Thin: thread-like but firm at any depth	Soggy: floating + thin + soft; disappears	Soggy is floating + soft; Thin is just narrow
Choppy vs Knotted	Choppy: rough texture; no missing beats	Knotted: beats actually MISSING (irregular)	Choppy = texture; Knotted = missing beats
結 vs 促 vs 代	結 Jié: slow + irregular skips	促 Cù: rapid + irregular skips	代 Dài: slow + REGULAR fixed-interval skips = worst prognosis
Empty vs Weak vs Frail	虛 Empty: soft + weak all levels	弱 Weak: deep + fine + soft	微 Frail: barely perceptible — most severe deficiency

PRE-LECTURE REFLECTION QUESTIONS

THINK ABOUT THESE BEFORE CLASS FRIDAY

1. What are the three essential qualities of a normal pulse (胃神根)? Describe each in your own words.
2. How would you differentiate a Floating Empty pulse (Yin def) from a Floating Tight pulse (Exterior Cold)?
3. A patient has a Slippery, Rapid pulse in the Left Guan. What pattern(s) should you consider first?
4. What makes Regularly Intermittent (代 Dài) the most serious of the three irregular rhythm pulses?
5. Name two pulses that are normal findings in certain contexts (not always pathological).
6. What is the difference between feeling pulse at three depth levels vs. simply noting "deep" or "shallow"?
7. How does Choppy differ from Thin — and what underlying condition does each suggest?

DANCE MEDICINE BRIDGE

Ballroom dancers develop hyperawareness of physical rhythm and timing. Your proprioceptive sensitivity to subtle shifts in music tempo, partner tension, and floor contact maps directly onto pulse palpation — especially detecting rhythm irregularities (代 Dài, 結 Jié, 促 Cù). Mention this in class participation.

YIN / YANG PULSE CLASSIFICATION — CAM Ch.13

YIN PULSES 陰脈 — generally deficient, interior, cold		YANG PULSES 陽脈 — generally excess, exterior, heat	
Pulse	Key Quality	Pulse	Key Quality
Deep 沉	Interior; pressed to bone	Floating 浮	Exterior; superficial
Slow 遲	Cold; Yang deficiency	Rapid 數	Heat; >5 beats/resp
Thin 細	Blood/Yin deficiency	Wiry 弦	Liver; pain; taut string
Empty 虛	Qi/Blood deficiency	Flooding 洪	Excess Heat; wave-like
Weak 弱	Deep, soft, fine	Slippery 滑	Phlegm; Damp; pregnancy
Choppy 澀	Blood stasis / def	Full 實	Excess; forceful all levels
Short 短	Qi def / stagnation	Tight 緊	Cold; pain; twisted rope
Knotted 結	Slow + irregular skips	Hurried 促	Rapid + irregular skips
Soggy 濡	Float + thin + soft	Long 長	Excess; extends past positions
Hidden 伏	Deepest; severe Cold	Racing 疾	Extreme Heat; >120 bpm
Frail 微	Barely perceptible	Firm 牢	Deep + wiry + hard

Mixed / Context-Dependent: Moderate 緩 (normal or Damp), Hollow 芤 (loss of Blood — Yin by nature but floating), Leather 革 (Jing/Blood loss), Regularly Intermittent 代 (organ decline), Overflowing 大 (Full Heat)